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From a Thane strongman to CM, Shinde's stormy rise over the years that culminated in a mega coup altered the course of Maharashtra politics

By Dhaval Kulkarni



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For years, speculation in Maharashtra had been rife: 'will he, won't he?' Some acolytes of Eknath Sambhaji Shinde said he had touched the glass ceiling and was looking for greener pastures, while others said he owed everything to the Shiv Sena and would never betray it. But when Shinde quit the party and joined hands with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in June 2022, toppling the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) government led by Uddhav Thackeray, he put these conjectures to rest and reaffirmed the old cliché: politics is the art of the possible.

The Shiv Sena is no stranger to splits, but Shinde's rebellion was a watershed as he walked away with 40 of 56 MLAs and 13 of 19 Lok Sabha MPs, fomenting an existential crisis for the party. Today, as Uddhav's 'Shiv Sena' stands sidelined, Shinde heads the 'Balasahebanchi Shiv Sena', which claims the legacy of the late Sena supremo Balasaheb Thackeray.

Hailing from Dare, a village in Satara, Shinde's family shifted to Mumbai's satellite city of Thane when he was in his teens. As a budding politician, he drove a rickshaw, launched a labour union, and became a party *shakha pramukh*. In 1997, he was elected to the Thane Municipal Corporation. Shinde's stormy rise, first under the patronage of the charismatic 'Dharmaveer' Anand Dighe and then by helping shore up the party's street power during its pitched battles with ex-Sena leader Narayan Rane, cemented his reputation in the power corridors as well as among masses, especially in Thane.

The Shiv Sena is no stranger to revolts, but Shinde's rebellion was a coup of sorts that plunged the party into an existential crisis

Shinde, however, presented a Catch-22 situation for Uddhav, who relied on him for muscle but was wary of mass leaders. The Thane strongman's vaulting ambitions were no secret either. Uddhav, thus, reportedly refused to appoint him the deputy CM in the Devendra Fadnavis-led coalition of 2014-19. Within the MVA, however, Thackeray's hands-off governance style and inaccessibility, coupled with the big-brother role of the Nationalist Congress Party, backfired, making Shinde, then the urban development minister, a go-to person for disgruntled Shiv Sena leaders. So, when Shinde finally decided to pull the plug on the MVA, he had the support of 49 other legislators.

Sceptics say that Shinde was a good number-two but he may not necessarily be the right helmsman. Nonetheless, for the BJP, his position ticks some boxes—he is a strong Maratha and a leader with a base around Mumbai. As the straws in the wind suggest, the BJP, after all, may have bigger plans for this rebel chief. ■